scientists and science fiction authors. As early as 1948 Alan Turing was exploring the possibility of creating what he termed ‘intelligent machinery’,[1] and in 1950 he postulated that computers would eventually be as smart as humans and might even be capable of masquerading as humans.[2] In 1968 computers could still not beat a human even at draughts,[3] but in *2001: A Space Odyssey* Arthur C. Clarke and Stanley Kubrick already envisioned HAL 9000 as a superintelligent AI rebelling against its human creators.

The rise of intelligent machines that can make decisions and create new ideas means that for the first time in history power is shifting away from humans and toward something else. Crossbows, muskets and atom bombs replaced human muscles in the act of killing, but they couldn’t replace human brains in deciding whom to kill. Little Boy – the bomb dropped on Hiroshima – exploded with a force of 12,500 tons of TNT,[4] but when it came to brainpower, Little Boy was a dud. It couldn’t decide anything.

It is different with computers. In terms of intelligence, computers far surpass not just atom bombs but also all previous information technology, such as clay tablets, printing presses and radio sets. Clay tablets stored information about taxes, but they couldn’t decide by themselves how much tax to levy, nor could they invent an entirely new tax. Printing presses copied information such as the Bible, but they couldn’t decide which texts to include in the Bible, nor could they write new commentaries on the holy book. Radio sets disseminated information such as political speeches and symphonies, but they couldn’t decide which speeches or symphonies to broadcast, nor could they compose them. Computers can do all these things. While printing presses and radio sets were passive tools in human hands, computers are already becoming active agents that escape our control and understanding and that can take initiatives in shaping society, culture and history.[5]

A paradigmatic case of the novel power of computers is the role that social media algorithms have played in spreading hatred and undermining social cohesion in numerous countries.[6] One of the earliest and most notorious such instances occurred in 2016–17, when Facebook algorithms helped fan the flames of anti-Rohingya violence in Myanmar (Burma).[7]

The early 2010s were a period of optimism in Myanmar. After decades of harsh military rule, strict censorship and international sanctions, an era of